Daan van der Weijden

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Research Interests

Artificial intelligence and its impact on democracy: conversational agents and voting advice applications, adaptive political surveys, online deliberation at scale, and the accessibility of complex political and legal information. Computational social science and human-centred machine learning, applied to societal problems in an interdisciplinary setting.

Education

Sep 2023 – present	**PhD in Computer Science** University of Zurich, Switzerland — DDIS, Department of Informatics Advisor: Prof. Dr. Abraham Bernstein. Part of the interdisciplinary Digital Deliberative Democracy (D3) project.
Sep 2021 – Aug 2023	**MSc in Artificial Intelligence** Utrecht University, the Netherlands Thesis: *Dutch Data Augmentation for Low-Resource Tasks*, carried out at TNO, The Hague. Supervisors: Prof. Dong Nguyen (Utrecht University) and Dr. Saskia Lensink (TNO). GPA 3.7/4.0. Graduate Honours of Interdisciplinary Seminars.
Sep 2019 – Aug 2021	**BSc in Artificial Intelligence *(cum laude)*** Utrecht University, the Netherlands Thesis: *Transitiviteit van Inferentie in Nederlandse Machine Learning NLI modellen*. Supervisor: Dr. Gijs Wijnholds. GPA 4.0/4.0.
Sep 2017 – Aug 2021	**BA in Linguistics** Utrecht University, the Netherlands Thesis: *Finding the Best Approach for Reasoning about Monotonicity*. Supervisor: Dr. Gijs Wijnholds. GPA 3.8/4.0.

Publications

My name is shown in bold. Listed newest first within each category.

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

[J1] Bachmann, F., **D. J. van der Weijden**, Sarasua, C., & Bernstein, A. (2026). Estimating the recommendation certainty in candidate-based voting advice applications. *Politics and Governance*, 14. doi:10.17645/pag.11256

[J2] Bachmann, F., **D. J. van der Weijden**, Heitz, L., Sarasua, C., & Bernstein, A. (2025). Adaptive political surveys and GPT-4: Tackling the cold start problem with simulated user interactions. *PLoS ONE*, 20(5), e0322690. doi:10.1371/journal.pone.0322690

[J3] van Es, K., **D. J. van der Weijden**, & Bakker, J. (2023). The multifaceted and situated data center imaginary of Dutch Twitter. *Big Data & Society*, 10(1). doi:10.1177/20539517231155064

Peer-Reviewed Conference Papers

[C1] **D. J. van der Weijden**, Brack, N., & Báez Santamaría, S. (2026). Reproducing and evaluating the generalizability of subliminal learning in open-weight models. In *Proceedings of the*

Ninth Workshop on Analyzing and Interpreting Neural Networks for NLP (BlackboxNLP '26), co-located with EMNLP 2026, Budapest, Hungary, pp. 1113–1120. Reproducibility Challenge track. doi:10.18653/2026.blackboxnlp-1.62

[C2] D. J. van der Weijden, Dieing, T. I., & Bachmann, F. (2026). Towards a typology of user engagement in conversational agent voting advice applications. In *Proceedings of the ACM Conference on Conversational User Interfaces (CUI '26)*, Bremen, Germany. doi:10.1145/3816046.3816272
Best Poster Honorable Mention. Equal author contribution.

[C3] Rossetto, L., Sarasua, C., Inel, O., Bermeo, J. D., Bolaños, P. S., Devimeux, H., Duan, H., Hany, R., Kyriakou, A., Ramasamy, D., Ravikumar, V. G., Timoleon, K., Vasu, R., Wang, R., **D. J. van der Weijden**, Willi, J., & Bernstein, A. (2025). Alan's Speakeasy — An ecosystem for the evaluation of conversational agents. In *Companion Proceedings of the ACM Web Conference 2025 (WWW '25)*, pp. 2895–2898. doi:10.1145/3701716.3715165
Demo Paper Third Place Award.

[C4] van Rosmalen, Y., van der Steen, F., Jans, S., & **D. J. van der Weijden** (2022). Bursting the burden bubble? An assessment of Sharma et al.'s counterfactual-based fairness metric. *Benelux Conference on Artificial Intelligence (BNAIC/BeNeLearn '22)*, Mechelen, Belgium. arXiv:2211.11512

Research Reports

[R1] Bakker, J., de Graaf, B. A., Prins, S., Schaefer, M., & **D. J. van der Weijden** (2024). *Playing with fire: How the interplay between the Dutch House of Representatives and social media fuels rage.* Utrecht University / Utrecht Data School. dataschool.nl

Awards, Grants & Honours

Jul 2026	**Best Poster Honorable Mention** ACM Conference on Conversational User Interfaces (CUI '26), Bremen
Jun 2026	**Engagement Award for Special Commitment *(nominee)*** Faculty of Business, Economics and Informatics, University of Zurich For work as PhD representative and member of hiring committees at the Department of Informatics.
Apr 2025	**CIRES Travel Grant** Funding a research visit to the University of Queensland, Brisbane
Apr 2025	**Demo Paper Third Place Award** The Web Conference 2025 (WWW '25), demo track
Sep 2024	**DSI PhD Excellence Program & Personal Grant** Digital Society Initiative, University of Zurich Competitive interdisciplinary programme; personal research grant of CHF 5,000.

Conference & Workshop Presentations

Oct 2026	**Reproducing and Evaluating the Generalizability of Subliminal Learning in Open-Weight Models** BlackboxNLP '26 at EMNLP 2026, Budapest — poster
Jul 2026	**Towards a Typology of User Engagement in CAVAAs** ACM Conference on Conversational User Interfaces (CUI '26), Bremen — poster
Nov 2025	**Personalised Summarisation for Swiss Leaflets** Digital Democracy Workshop, Digital Society Initiative, University of Zurich With Cristina Sarasua and Abraham Bernstein.
Jun 2025	**AutoDQI: An Automated Measurement of Deliberation Quality**

EDDY 2025, Centre d'Économie de la Sorbonne, Paris

Apr 2024 — **Partisan Bots or Neutral Models? Politically Aligning Large Language Models**
EDDY 2024 — Digital Democracy: Bridging Theory and Practice, Erasmus University Rotterdam — poster
With Fynn Bachmann, Cristina Sarasua and Abraham Bernstein.

Nov 2022 — **Bursting the Burden Bubble?**
BNAIC/BeNeLearn 2022, Mechelen

Jun 2022 — **Infrastructures of Data Power: Revisiting the Twitter Debate on Data Centers in the Netherlands**
Dialogues in Data Power, ZeMKI, University of Bremen
With Karin van Es and Jeroen Bakker.

Jun 2022 — **Interviewing an Algorithm: Developing a Research Method for Critical Inquiry into Algorithmic Systems from a Socio-Cultural Perspective**
Dialogues in Data Power, ZeMKI, University of Bremen
With Iris Muis, Mirko Tobias Schäfer, and Arthur Vankan.

Student Supervision

Sep 2025 – Sep 2026 — **Marlon Gelpke & Kim Hyeongseok — *Debate Bots: A Multi-Agent Interactive Environment for Swiss Political Debates***
MSc research project, University of Zurich
Co-supervised with Selene Báez Santamaría.

Sep 2025 – Mar 2026 — **Jana Joy Muheim — *Designing Debate Bots Interface***
BSc thesis, University of Zurich

Jul 2025 – Jan 2026 — **Wesley Muri — *Clustering Swiss Politics***
MSc thesis, University of Zurich

Oct 2024 – Oct 2025 — **Zihan Liu & Zehao Zhang — *Front-End Enhancement of the Online Discussion Platform CitizenOS***
MSc research project, University of Zurich

May 2024 – Nov 2024 — **Hasan Atak — *Automated Drafting of Swiss Popular Initiatives Through Large Language Models***
MSc thesis, University of Zurich

Feb 2024 – Aug 2024 — **Julian Novoa Martin — *Improving the Automatic Measure of Discourse Quality***
MSc thesis, University of Zurich

Aug 2023 – Jul 2024 — **Wesley Muri & Yuru Jin — *Practical Applications of Large-Language Models for Legal Use Cases***
MSc research project, University of Zurich
Co-supervised with Fynn Bachmann.

Teaching

Fall 2024, Fall 2025 — **Advanced Topics in Artificial Intelligence**
Teaching assistant, MSc course, University of Zurich

Fall 2022 — **Machine Learning**
Teaching assistant, Utrecht University

Spring 2021 — **Natural and Formal Languages**
Teaching assistant, Utrecht University

Fall 2020 — **Introduction to Logic**
Teaching assistant, Utrecht University

Research & Professional Experience

Dec 2022 – Aug 2023 — **Research Intern**
TNO, The Hague
Researched textual data augmentation methods; developed augmentation techniques for Dutch using locally hosted large language models.

Jan 2022 – Jun 2024 — **Research Assistant**
Utrecht Data School, Utrecht
Analysed Twitter discourse on Dutch data centers (published in *Big Data & Society*); developed an algorithmic oversight framework for public authorities; conducted research on political influence on social media.

Research Visits

2025 — **Visiting Researcher**
University of Queensland, Brisbane, Australia
Funded by a CIRES Travel Grant.

Academic Service & Engagement

Current — **PhD Representative**
Department of Informatics (IfI), University of Zurich
Represents the doctoral community; member of hiring committees.

2024 – 2026 — **Member of the Faculty Assembly**
Faculty of Business, Economics and Informatics (OEC), University of Zurich

2024 — **Reviewer**
AAAI/ACM Conference on AI, Ethics, and Society (AIES '24); Extended Semantic Web Conference (ESWC 2024); Digital Democracy Workshop 2024

2024 — **Organising Committee, Digital Democracy Workshop 2024**
Digital Society Initiative & Digital Democracy Lab, University of Zurich

2019 – 2021 — **Faculty Council Member**
Faculty of Humanities, Utrecht University

2019 – 2020 — **Chair, student political party VUUR**
Utrecht University

2018 – 2019 — **Chair, Linguistics study association**
Utrecht University

Languages

Dutch (native), English (fluent), German (working knowledge)

Last updated: November 9, 2026.